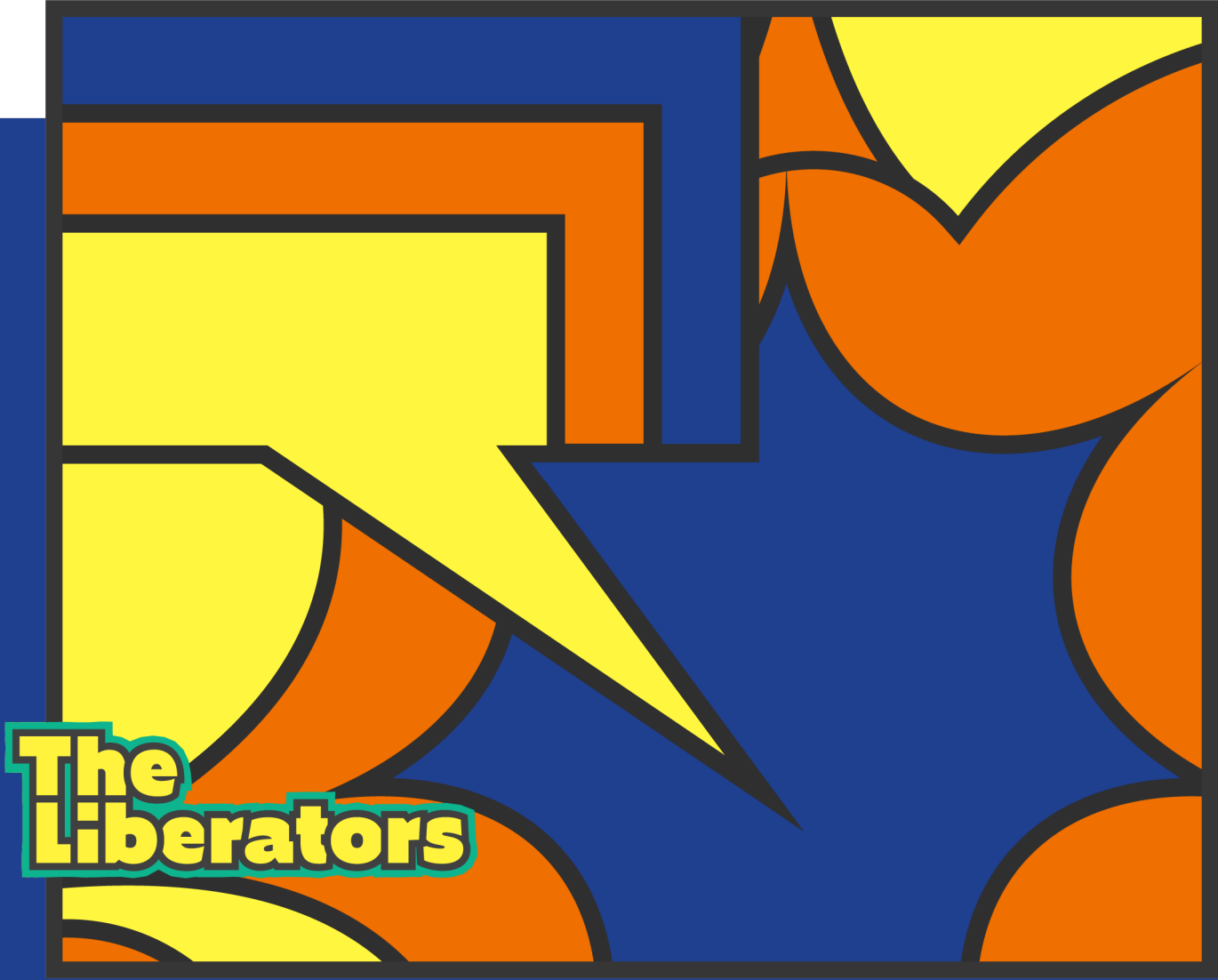


Identify Creative Solutions To Automate Releases And Ship Faster

A do-it-yourself workshop to diagnose the level of release automation in your team, and identify where you can make improvements

An abstract graphic featuring a dark blue background with large, bold, stylized shapes in orange and yellow. The shapes include a large 'L' shape, a large 'M' shape, and a large 'S' shape. The text 'The Liberators' is written in a bold, yellow, sans-serif font with a black outline, positioned in the bottom left corner of the graphic.

**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

One of the pillars of our [book](#), and the Scrum framework itself, is "Ship It Fast". But shipping fast quickly becomes a burden when it involves a lot of manual work, like manual pre-deploy backups, writing deployment scripts, and testing critical paths manually every time. When releases feel like a burden, teams often postpone them into larger batches (like once a quarter or once a year) or they skip quality assurance steps and release low-quality work to their stakeholders.

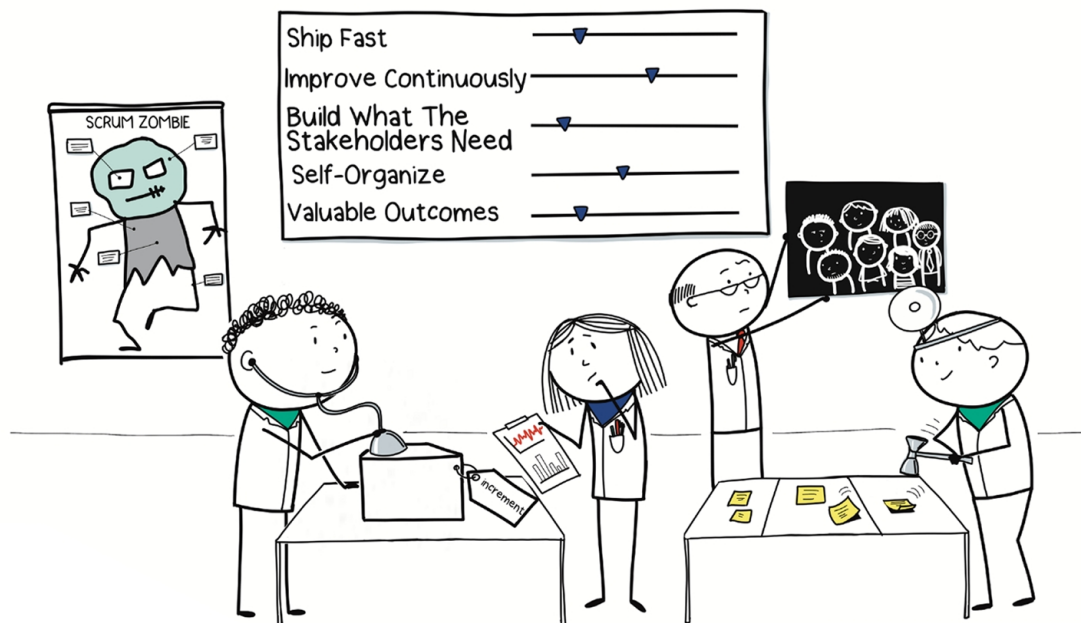
It is completely understandable for teams to balk at the idea of "releasing after every Sprint" when the amount of manual work is so large, let alone the idea to release each individual feature. And while most teams know that automation can theoretically support them here by taking most of that work out of their hands, they don't even know where to start untangling the knot of challenges.

At the same time, it is hard to capture the joy when your release pipeline is automated to the point where each release becomes a trivial matter and the speed it brings to how fast new work can be shipped to stakeholders.

We designed this workshop to get your team started with release automation, or improve and expand the automation already in place. Give it a try, and let us know the results.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow

Step 1: Opening	 3 min
Step 2: Inventorize Release Activities With "1-2-4-ALL"	  20 min
Step 3: Analyze The Status Quo With "Ecocycle Planning"	  50 min
Step 4: Identify Most Impactful Next Steps With "1-2-4-ALL"	  20 min
Step 5: Personal Next Steps	  10 min
Step 6: Closing	 2 min
Total duration	 105 min

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill	☆☆☆☆	While the flow of this workshop is easy, experience with facilitation is helpful for Ecocycle Planning.
Impact On Survival	☆☆☆☆☆	Automating your release process is one of the most powerful enablers of shipping fast (and high quality!).



How To Prepare



Group Size

This workshop is suited for individual Scrum teams, ranging between 4 and 12 participants, and takes about 2 hours. The steps also work well for much larger groups, or even multiple Scrum teams together, but you will need more time.

Intended Audience

This string is designed for Scrum teams. If your team is highly dependant on others to perform releases, you can invite a few of those people to the workshop as well. If you have powerful stakeholders that both benefit from higher release frequencies *and* appreciate the challenge of automation, you can include them in the workshop too. They may turn out to be your biggest champions.

Virtual Delivery

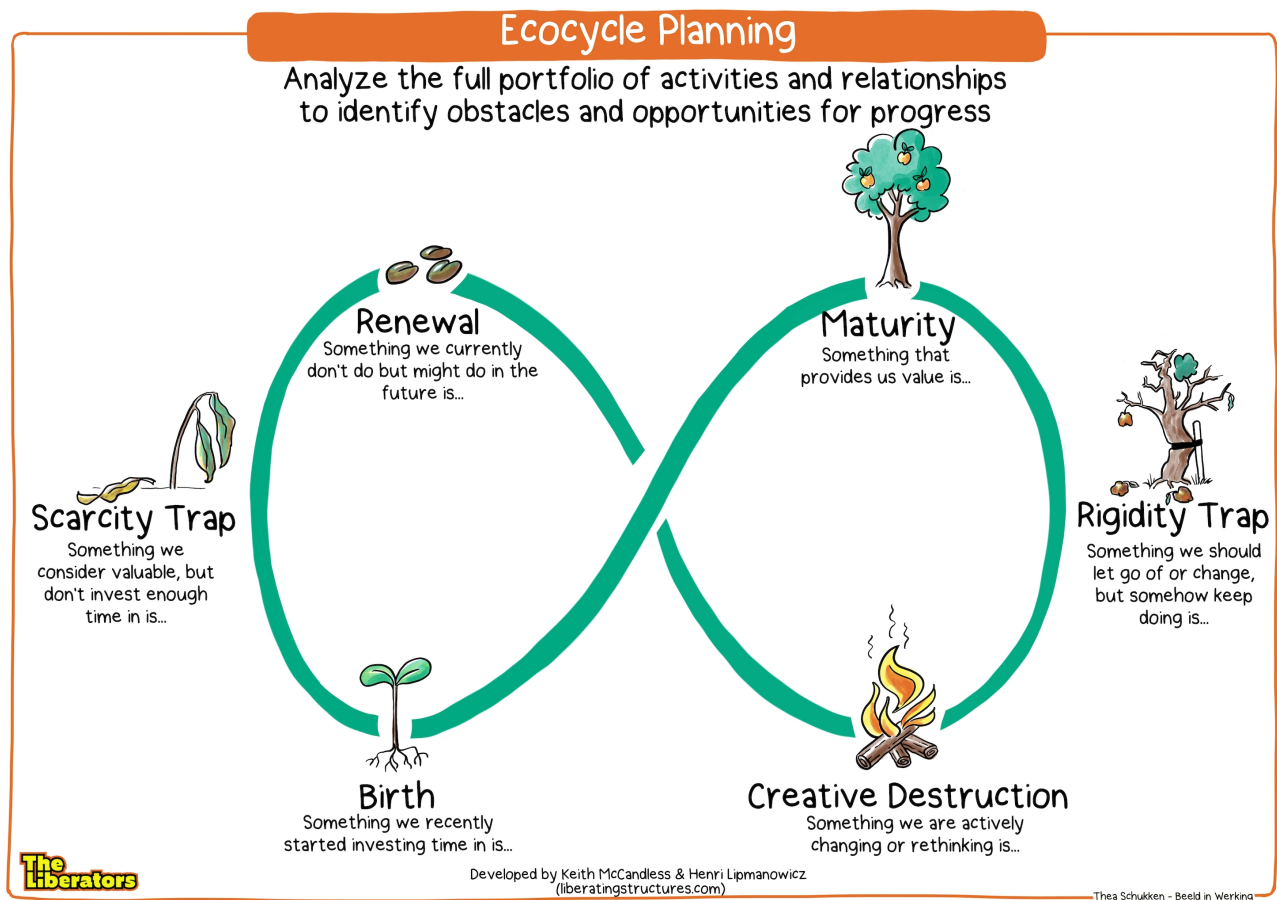
We've successfully used this exercise with virtual teams. It does require preparation and the right tools. In our work, we purposefully follow the principles of [Liberating Structures](#) and break down interactions into smaller groups to allow *everyone* to contribute – and not just the loud voices and know-it-alls. If you are working with a group beyond five participants, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#).

Material

- Create one shared, empty canvas for Ecocycle Planning (see the picture further down) on the floor, wall or a shared virtual workspace.
- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- Bring colored stickies if you're doing this in-person.



Ecocycle Planning: A Metaphor From Nature



Ecocycle Planning is part of the repertoire of Liberating Structures. Its purpose is to analyze the full portfolio of activities and identify obstacles and opportunities for progress in a markedly non-linear way. That makes it an excellent way to periodically reflect on your work together and to decide what to focus on next. It is based on the life cycle in nature.

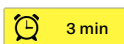
The activities of your Scrum team can be plotted on an Ecocycle as follows:

- **Renewal** represents all the activities that you think would be useful to you as a team, but that you are not doing at the moment.
- **Birth** represents the activities that you have just started doing as a team, or that you've been investing in. Although they are not fully valuable yet, and probably take effort and discipline to do, they will become increasingly valuable as you keep doing them.
- **Maturity** represents the activities that are comfortable and valuable to you as a team. It doesn't take much effort or discipline to do them. It's become part of your rhythm as a Scrum Team.
- **Creative Destruction** represents the activities that have either lost their value to you as a team or need to be reinvented in order to become useful again. Perhaps by doing it in a different way or from a different perspective. Or you want to stop doing them altogether.



All activities flow through the Ecocycle. But they can also get stuck. Activities that you know are important but are never invested in, get stuck in the Poverty/Scarcity Trap. Activities that you keep doing, but aren't really adding any value any longer, are in the Rigidity Trap. By plotting all your activities across the Ecocycle, you can identify patterns that tell you something about where you are as a team. Look for the following patterns in particular:

- A healthy Ecocycle is balanced. There is innovation taking place, as evidenced by activities on the left of the model, and there are activities that are mature, as evidenced by items on the right. Furthermore, teams are continuously reinventing how to do things and become better, as represented in what is in Creative Destruction.
- Activities that are in the Rigidity Trap and Creative Destruction are prime candidates for reinvention or even removal. Start there before adding new activities, as this creates space for something new.

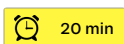


3 min

Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



20 min



Step 2: Inventorize Release Activities With "1-2-4-ALL"

If we want to discover where automation is possible, we first need to know what usually happens during a release. This gives us the anchor points to make changes in the real world. The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is a great way to quickly tap into the mind of the team to inventorize this list together.

The activities can range from testing activities (e.g. "running UI tests on dev machine" or "performing critical paths on mobile devices") to documentation (e.g. "write release notes" or "send update e-mail"). You can also think about making different types of backups, monitoring the product before and after deployment, creating deployment packages, security checks, performance tests, user training, and everything else that may already be on your Definition of Done.

Invitation

"When a scientist would observe the process we all go through for a high-quality release, which steps, activities, and operations would they observe? Make a list of all the meaningful steps that happen, automated or manual."

Steps

1. **2 min** Ask everyone to first individually and silently reflect on the question and start compiling a list.
2. **4 min** Invite people into pairs to combine and deduplicate their lists and expand them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3. **6 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and combine and deduplicate their lists and expand them together. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms. If you do this in person, it works best to ask the small groups to turn the items on their list into a set of individual stickies.
4. **5 min** When everyone is back together, collect the lists from the small groups on a shared workplace (i.e. a

whiteboard, the floor, or a virtual workspace). Deduplicate the items and create a single numbered list. The numbers are simply there to simplify the next step and don't imply order.

Our Findings

- If the team struggles to identify activities at all, you can use a Liberating Structure like [Simple Ethnography](#) to invite a few members of the workshop to first observe how releases take place in practice first.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with [1-2-4-ALL](#)





Step 3: Analyze The Status Quo With "Ecocycle Planning"



With the numbered list of activities that you created in the previous step, now is a good time to diagnose the degree to which they are already automated.

Invitation

Step 2: "Plot the activities from the numbered list on your Ecocycle based on how automated you think they are"

Step 5: "What does the placement of the activities say about how we're investing in automation? What patterns are emerging?"

Steps

1. **10 min** Introduce Ecocycle Planning. Briefly explain the metaphor, the quadrants, and give some examples to help people understand it. Activities that are fully automated and effortless go into "Maturity". Those activities where your team has begun automation go into "Birth", while those that are fully manual go into "Renewal". Some activities may be wasteful or ineffective in their current form altogether (automated or not) and go to "Creative Destruction". Activities that would save you a lot of trouble when automated, but aren't getting that attention, go into the "Poverty Trap". Finally, some activities may be taking place – manual or automated – but it may be unclear if they're still helpful. These go into the "Rigidity Trap".
2. **10 min** Invite people to individually fill in an Ecocycle Planning for the team. Either direct everyone to their individual empty canvas in your collaboration tool or ask people to draw an Ecocycle Planning on a piece of paper. Give them time to silently distributing the numbers of the activities across their own Ecocycle. In the meantime, prepare breakouts for groups of four.
3. **3 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, introduce the shared and empty Ecocycle Canvas. Explain that people will be working together in the next steps to create a single Ecocycle Planning for their Scrum Team that

combines all their perspectives.

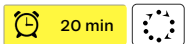
4. **10 min** Invite people into small groups (2–3 people) and into their own breakouts. Ask the small groups to share their Ecocycles and agree on the placement of each activity, and then put the number of that activity on the shared Ecocycle. So at the end of this round, each small group should have put all the numbers of the list you created together somewhere on the Ecocycle.
5. **8 min** Now that you have created a shared Ecocycle, ask: "What does the placement of the activities say about how we're investing in automation? What patterns are emerging?". Give people a moment to take in the Ecocycle and get their thinking started **2 min** and then invite them into pairs, or breakouts **6 min**.
6. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the pairs to share the patterns they found the most insightful.

Our Findings

- Ecocycle Planning is about seeing both the trees (the activities) and the forest (the distribution). When the group focuses entirely on individual activities, draw their attention to overall patterns or vice versa.

Additional resources

- Blog post: [Help Development Teams Advance Their Technical Practices With Ecocycle Planning](#)
- Blog post: [Create focus with Ecocycle Planning](#)
- Product: [Ecocycle Planning for Scrum Teams](#)
- The official page for [Ecocycle Planning](#) on LiberatingStructures.com



20 min

Step 4: Identify Most Impactful Next Steps With "1-2-4-ALL"

Now that you've created transparency, and explored how your team is investing in automation, we're going to shift the focus to the next steps. The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) that we used in the introduction is again very powerful here. We're also purposefully using it twice to demonstrate how the same structure can be used from different perspectives.

Invitation

"If we would do this Ecocycle again in a month, what are creative first steps you see now, that would move one or more activities along the Ecocycle by then?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Ask everyone to first individually and silently generate ideas.
2. **4 min** Invite people into pairs to share the ideas they have and pick the one they think is the most impactful and realistic.
3. **6 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and (again) share their ideas and refine them together to make them as simple to start with as possible.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask each group to present their ideas. Work together to end with 1, 2, or 3 actionable ideas to start moving items across the Ecocycle



Step 5: Personal Next Steps

Up to this point, the conversation has focused on what the Scrum team can do to automate their release pipeline. We always like to close workshops like this by asking individual members how they will personally contribute to those next steps. The Liberating Structure 15% Solutions is well-suited for this purpose and keeps those next steps manageable.

Invitation

"What is your personal 15% Solution to contribute to the few next steps we identified? What is something, or a next step, you can do that you do without permission from other or resources you don't have access to?"



Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partner find a way to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).
3. **2 min** When everyone is together, ask people to add their 15% Solutions to a shared workspace and briefly mention what they intend to do. You can keep these 15% Solutions transparent by adding them to the Sprint Backlog, or the Product Backlog for future Sprints.

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?".

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

Step 6: Closing

With this workshop, you have diagnosed the level of release automation in your team and worked together to identify a few first steps to make progress. We recommend that you keep the Ecocycle around so that you can inspect it periodically to see where you should invest energy next.

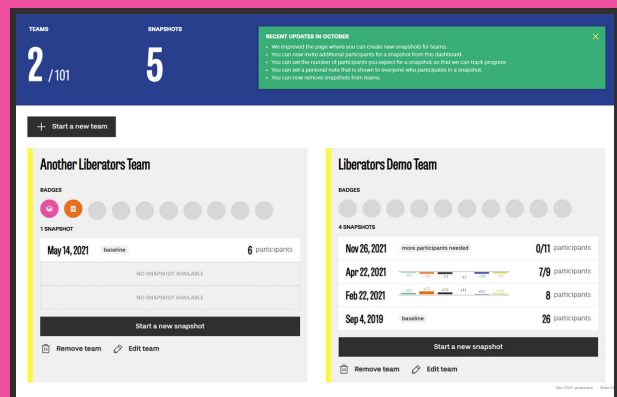
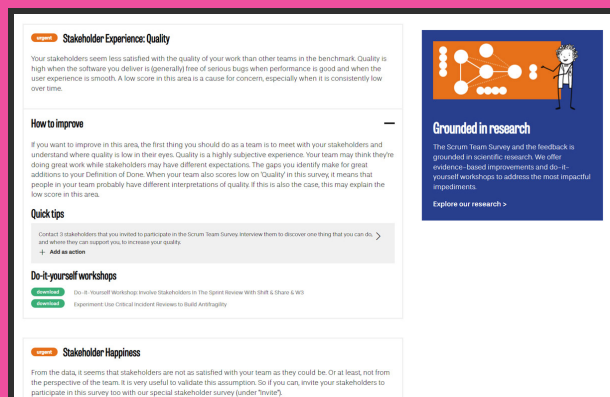
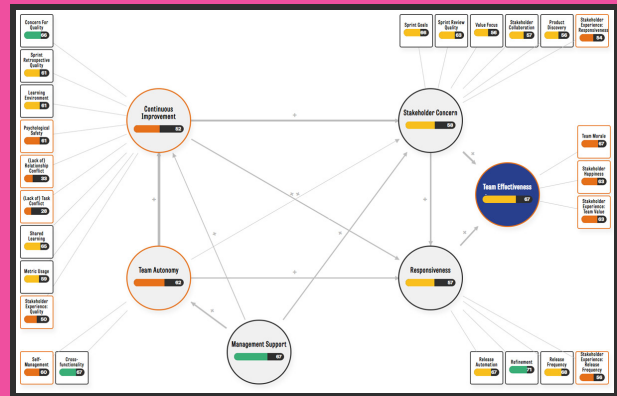
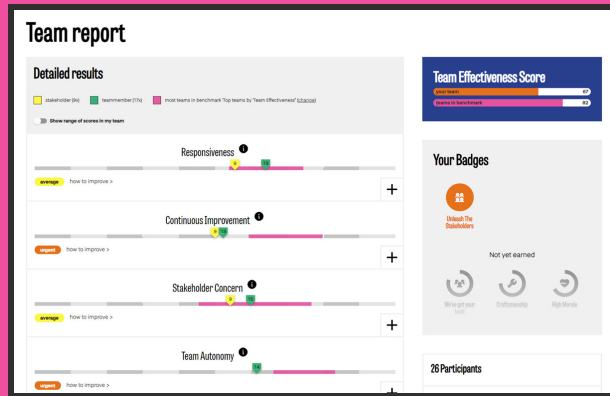
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



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Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
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